

Chapter 42-3

Liang Shi felt somewhat restless and uneasy after sitting down.

The quiet environment left her not knowing what to do, and all the dishes on the table made her feel guilty.

Everything had been prepared by Xu Qingzhu herself.

She hadn't contributed anything.

Moreover, after Xu Qingzhu returned from the mall, she hadn't mentioned a single word about what happened in the morning.

Last time she had asked about Jiaojiao, but this time she said nothing at all.

Liang Shi, who was used to being questioned whenever something unusual happened, couldn't adapt to this sudden change.

Although this was the best choice for her and the most comfortable approach.

But it made her feel guilty.

Clearly, this matter was also related to Xu Qingzhu.

Qi Taitai had said in front of Xu Qingzhu that she and Qi Jiao were somewhat similar.

The information revealed was that for Liang Shi, she was just a substitute for Qi Jiao.

Yet Xu Qingzhu still gave her sufficient patience.

As long as she didn't speak, Xu Qingzhu wouldn't ask.

Liang Shi couldn't stand this somewhat oppressive atmosphere and finally couldn't help but laugh and speak up, "Where did you order the takeout from?"

"From an app." Xu Qingzhu sat there very calmly, also answering her question normally, though she frowned slightly before answering. This subtle movement was instantly caught by Liang Shi, who interpreted it as possible disdain for her ignorance.

Xu Qingzhu continued: "From a food delivery app. After ordering, they deliver it."

Liang Shi replied with little confidence: "Mm."

Then the atmosphere sank again.

Liang Shi became a bit more animated, asking: "What time did you wake up today? How long did you sleep?"

These were very boring questions.

After asking, she herself realized that these questions were actually quite elementary.

Normally, she would never ask such things.

She had always been someone with a good sense of boundaries, especially with Xu Qingzhu.

At most, she would ask "Did you sleep well?"

But now she didn't want the conversation to go cold, or rather, she didn't dare let it go cold.

She felt unsettled inside.

Xu Qingzhu looked up upon hearing this, those clear eyes carelessly scanning over, as if wanting to take in all of Liang Shi's unease and panic.

"Can't remember clearly." Xu Qingzhu still answered her question, "When I woke up, it was already dark, and the rain had been falling for a long time."

"Right." Liang Shi shrugged with forced casualness, "We were quite lucky with our timing. It started raining not long after we got back. I slept from when I got back until now, so I probably won't be able to sleep tonight."

"Then we'll watch a movie." Xu Qingzhu said: "Watch until you get sleepy, then sleep."

With this conversation, Liang Shi finally relaxed a bit.

But once Xu Qingzhu finished answering, the conversation went cold again.

That sense of urgency and unease surged up again, forcing her to find topics.

"So do you have plans tomorrow..." Liang Shi started asking again, but before she could finish, Xu Qingzhu interrupted, "Liang Shi."

She called Liang Shi's name very casually, with a touch of nonchalance, and even the gaze that swept over carried a gentle quality.

"You don't need to find topics." Xu Qingzhu said: "Just wait for the food."

Liang Shi: "..."

"I don't have anything I want to answer." Xu Qingzhu continued: "And you don't have anything good to ask. As for things like weather, they're normally not within our scope of concern, so just be yourself, okay? It's just eating a meal together. After eating, do whatever you want to do. There's no need to exhaust yourself like this."

Liang Shi instinctively wanted to explain: "I didn't..."

"I know you're waiting for me to ask about what happened this morning." Xu Qingzhu said: "But I don't plan to ask. Things you haven't figured out yourself—there's no point in me asking."

Liang Shi: "..."

She began to be amazed by Xu Qingzhu's perceptiveness and intelligence.

In such a short time, she had actually seen through all of this.

"I asked Zhao Xuning about it. Qi Taitai doesn't usually appear much in social circles, and her husband, CEO Qi of Qida Company, has built up a persona of being a doting husband and loving father. Qi Jiao is even more mysterious. She was normally a transparent person at school, but suddenly wanted to jump off a building in her third year of junior high. She didn't succeed that day and was hospitalized for a while. After changing schools, she became virtually untraceable in social circles." Xu Qingzhu laid out all the information she had learned in front of her, "If you want to investigate, you can start from Qi Jiao's side."

Liang Shi was surprised, "You... why are you helping me?"

The water began to boil.

Xu Qingzhu put a plate of meat into the pot, "Consider it helping myself."

Liang Shi: "Hm?"

Xu Qingzhu: "I don't want to eat while looking at an extremely dejected face."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Especially a dejected face that's trying to put on a happy front to make others happy." Xu Qingzhu's face was obscured by the rising steam, making her look ethereal. She had no expression as usual, her voice still clear and cold, but the words she spoke were like sunshine, warm enough to melt one's heart.

"If you're unhappy, you're unhappy. What's there to hide?" Xu Qingzhu said: "No one needs you to coax them to be happy. Everyone has the freedom to be happy or unhappy."

Xu Qingzhu placed the plate on the table, "Liang Shi, you are free."